

AYUSH MHATRE, 17
Chennai Super Kings

MATCHES: 7 RUNS: 240
AVG: 34.3 STRIKE RATE: 189

Five-time champions Chennai Super Kings had a season to forget, but if there was a lone star who shone bright, it was Ayush Mhatre, the youngest player to don the yellow jersey. After going unsold at the IPL auction, the teenage sensation from Mumbai suburb Nalasopara made the most of the opportunity when he got called in mid-campaign to fill in for injured captain Ruturaj Gaikwad. And in just seven matches, he cast a spell, hitting 31 fours and 11 sixes in the process. His aggressive approach paid off particularly well in the power play sessions. Few who were there will forget the 94 off 48 balls he struck against RCB at the Chinnaswamy stadium, earning praise from 'Thala' M.S. Dhoni himself who called him a "champion" in the making. Then there was the pounding he gave Mumbai Indians pacer Ashwani Kumar, knocking him back for a four and two sixes off consecutive balls. Any wonder then that Mhatre was named captain of the Under-19 Indian side that will tour England later this month. —*SS*

SAI KISHORE, 28
Gujarat Titans

MATCHES: 15 WICKETS: 19
ECONOMY: 9.25 STRIKE RATE: 13.4

Sai Kishore was the ultimate 'take-one-for-the-team' man for Gujarat Titans in IPL 2025. GT had used their RTM (right-to-match) card to retain him, but with another great spinner, Rashid Khan, also in the side, the 193 cm tall left arm spinner saw matches fly by with his full quota of overs going unutilised. But Kishore kept to his task, even bowling the final over of the innings on occasion and picking up wickets. He also developed a variation of a carrom ball, an unusual development for a leftie twirler. All the effort seems to have paid off, for with 19 wickets and a fantastic strike rate, he has shown his worth for the first time in a full season. Having previously played only 10 games in two seasons combined, Kishore used all his domestic cricket experience to become GT's, well, ultimate utility bowler.

—*Siddharth Viswanathan*

PRIYANSH ARYA, 23, *Punjab Kings*

MATCHES: 17 RUNS: 475
AVG: 27.9 STRIKE RATE: 179.3

Priyansh Arya made his mark in the Delhi Premier League with six sixes in one over. This earned the southpaw some major attention in the 2025 IPL auction where the Punjab Kings grabbed him for Rs 3.8 crore (base price: Rs 30 lakh). In hindsight, that looks like money well spent as Arya teamed up with Prabhsimran Singh to become one of the most destructive opening partnerships this IPL. The grapevine has it that his coach took him to Ratapani Tiger Reserve near Bhopal to train "without distrac-

